In the workshop with... John Austin

The Essex turner extols the therapeutic benefits of his hobby...

Born in July 1937 in Dartford, Kent, John Austin had a conventional childhood, although like most children of the era, it was marked by WWII. He first bought a roundbed lathe on impulse to provide him with a hobby upon his retirement. This came sooner rather than later for John when a restructuring process at his then employer saw him leave work aged 60. He has been woodturning since and co-founded Chelmer Valley Woodturners, where he is now Chairman.

PHOTOGRAPHS BY JOHN AUSTIN

How, when and why did you start turning?

I started at Gravesend Grammar School for Boys in 1948, where the first-year curriculum contained the usual subjects, plus woodwork and metalwork. The woodwork resulted in a stool made of mahogany (*Khaya ivorensis*) and oak (*Quercus robur*) along with a platter.

Some 47 years on, I bought my first roundbed lathe. Around the same time, I purchased some fuchsia plants from a local nursery and saw it was home to a woodturning club – BHP Woodcrafts, now Sandon Woodturners. In the intervening years, I had been a chief technician with the RAF and a technical author for Marconi Communication Systems Ltd. relocating to Chelmsford, Essex. Since my retirement from the latter, my hobby has kept me active. I stress the hobby aspect as I am not a production/professional turner; that would be a job. Now I am free to enjoy my turning as and when the mood takes me. I can also vouch for the therapeutic value of woodturning. In 2000, I was diagnosed with prostate cancer and needed major surgery. It took me a while to recover and no heavy lifting was allowed.

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